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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1954-1957

Coverage Date: 1930-1957

Place Coverage

Community of Nyansongo, South Nyanza District, Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): THE LINEAGE SYSTEM

Many incidents occurring in Nyansongo, where everyone belongs to the same clan, indicated that *ensoni* between adjacent generations is not merely a matter of formal etiquette but a feeling experienced by individuals. A beer party discussion of venereal disease and adultery was abruptly stopped by a group of men when a classificatory daughter of some of them arrived on the scene. When a middle-aged woman was describing supernatural punishment for adultery to the ethnographer, her real daughter and a classificatory daughter-in-law giggled for a while, then retired to another house in the homestead, and warned away other visitors of their generation. During the female initiation ceremonies, when women, especially those of middle age, are permitted to disregard verbal and physical modesty as they sing and dance in public places, the younger men—their classificatory sons—assiduously avoided these places whenever possible. When by ritual necessity or accident they were present at such occasions, the men displayed signs of acute embarrassment and fled at the first opportunity. Sexual embarrassment is more intense between persons who are not only of adjacent generational layers but also of opposite sex. An informant expressed the mortification experienced by the crowd at a magical ceremony when two chickens happened to copulate, by saying, "It was shameful; 'fathers' and 'daughters' were there."

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Feelings of sexual shame can be avoided by conformity to the avoidance rules for persons of adjacent generations. With kin of the parental generation within the clan (and parents-in-law outside) one may not: shake hands (customary greeting between equals), sleep in the same house (except for adjacent generation females), bathe together or see each other naked, engage in joking insults (which are usually obscene), discuss sexual topics freely, or argue freely. The last mentioned rule is sometimes considered separately as "respect" (*ogosika*), since it is a prohibition on verbal aggression rather than sexual immodesty as such. In general, the attitude of respect is more important for conduct toward "little fathers" and sex avoidance more important with "little mothers." The maintenance of properly restrained

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behavior causing embarrassment to no one is facilitated by the use of an elaborate euphemistic vocabulary for sex and bodily functions in discussion between adjacent generation persons.

The rules governing relationships between clansmen not of adjacent generations require less restraint and involve less embarrassment; they lack the elements of sex avoidance and respect which characterize classificatory parent-child relations. This lack of restraint is particularly striking in relations between an individual and his real or classificatory  34 grandparents. He may discuss sex and insult them jokingly. In fact, the characteristic pattern of interaction in this relationship involves obscene insults, humorous inquiries about sexual activity, and deprecation of the other's sexual competence. Despite the reciprocal nature of this warm, joking relationship, real grandparents may make economic demands which must be respected by the grandchild. If a classificatory grandparent is approximately the same age as the grandchild, their relations are as free and equal as if they were of the same generational status. Great-grandparents, however, are "like parents" and must be treated with the respect and sex avoidance required in adjacent-generation relations.

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